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woolsey fire - NASA says field lab still 'intact' - No threat: Lawmakers dispute claim site only has 'scorch marks'

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NASA said its assessment team is inspecting the Santa Susana Field Laboratory following the deadly Woolsey fire that started Nov. 8, downing power lines, burning oak trees and charring a massive swath of land near the former rocket engine test and nuclear research site in Simi Valley.

"NASA has been working on-site to mitigate fire damage, help clear the roadways and power poles,

and repair equipment destroyed by fire," according to an update NASA posted on its website.

The 2,900-acre test site was developed in the 1940s, and in 1959 it had a partial meltdown accident that left the area polluted with radioactive and chemical contamination.

In 2010, NASA and the U.S. Department of Energy agreed to clean up all detectable contamination by 2017. Officials also asked Boeing, which owns a portion of the site, to launch its own cleanup. Despite the 2017 deadline, no parties have started cleaning up yet.

All test sites, including Alfa, Bravo and Coca test areas, remained "intact with no apparent damage beyond scorch marks near pedestals and a burned wooden staircase at Alfa 1," according to the website.

"NASA assessments confirm no specific risks or hazards from the fire associated with contamination at the site," the post said.

State Sen. Henry Stern, D-Canoga Park, and Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, D-Van Nuys, didn't agree with the agency's assessment.

In a letter sent Monday,to the California Department of Toxic Substances Control, which oversees the long-planned cleanup of the site, Stern and Gabriel — whose districts touch the lab property nestled in an area between Simi Valley, West Hills and Agoura Hills — urged the department to be "as forthcoming and transparent as possible to allow for indecent public oversight."

"There are serious questions about potential public health risks to neighboring communities and others in the path of the Woolsey fire," the letter said.

The letter calls for a release of all data from the soil, air, ash and other samples taken at or near the field lab in addition to a detailed summary of the monitoring equipment located at the site.

Representatives for NASA didn't respond to requests for comment.

Abbott Dutton, a spokeswoman for DTSC, said the agency is still evaluating any damage caused by the fire.

"The fire did not burn SSFL facilities that previously handled radioactive and hazardous materials," Dutton said. "It did not extend to the former radioactive materials handling facility, hazardous waste treatment facility, and sodium reactor experiment area, and other buildings in that area."

NASA said its areas will remain closed until Fridayand only emergency response activities are allowed on-site.

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